Is the U.S. Freight Recovery Real?

Data snapshot 2026-11-01 | Analysis as of 2026-11-02 UTC

A demand-led freight recovery is not yet established.

Are U.S. freight conditions recovering on volume and underlying pricing, or is the improvement in reported revenue and price indices mostly fuel-cost pass-through? Which business models benefit, and how much is already reflected in valuations?

01 | Demand

Truck tonnage -0.4% YoY (2026-07); Cass shipments +1.9% YoY (2026-09); Freight Transportation Services Index -2.0% YoY (2026-07). [1] [2] [3]

Read shipment activity separately from nominal spending. These series cover different periods and segments; they are not a single contemporaneous demand measure.

02 | Pricing

Truckload PPI +17.9% YoY; residual -9.7pp relative to its historical diesel relationship (2026-09). [4] [5]

The residual is a statistical comparison, not a direct measure of ex-fuel rates or a causal fuel decomposition. Direct ex-fuel rate evidence is still needed.

03 | Company conversion

KNX operating-margin change +5.5pp YoY (Q3 2026); JBHT operating-margin change -1.2pp YoY (Q3 2026); CHRW operating-margin change -0.3pp YoY (Q3 2026). [6] [7] [8]

Check whether revenue growth converts into profit. Mix, acquisitions and cost timing are rival explanations; consolidated results alone do not identify pricing power.

Alternative explanations

• Fuel, freight mix and contract-reset timing can move headline prices. A diesel regression residual does not isolate their separate effects.
• Acquisitions, segment mix and cost timing can explain company margin differences. Consolidated results do not establish pricing power.

What I would investigate next

1. **Test underlying rates.** Match ex-fuel spot and contract rate changes with shipment activity in the same period; sustained gains in both would strengthen the recovery case.

2. **Explain profit conversion.** Reconcile segment volumes, ex-fuel yield and fuel recovery in public earnings releases; use common-quarter comparisons before assigning a mechanism.

3. **Challenge the view in calls.** Ask private shippers, fleet owners and brokers about comparable operations, then cross-check first-hand observations and disagreements. Fieldwork is planned, not completed.

Sources | links lead to the original series or filing

[1] Truck Tonnage Index
[2] Cass Freight Index: Shipments
[3] Freight Transportation Services Index
[4] Fuel-adjusted residual: Truckload PPI (long-distance)
[5] US Diesel Sales Price
[6] Knight-Swift Transportation 10-Q (filed 2026-10-28)
[7] J.B. Hunt Transport Services 10-Q (filed 2026-10-23)
[8] C.H. Robinson Worldwide 10-Q (filed 2026-10-30)

Independent public-data writing sample. No primary interviews are included. Observation periods differ; source figures and statistical proxies do not establish causality. No consensus expectations or investment recommendation is asserted.